Born to Be Blue

By Mark Bellusci

RON: Look, I'm not trying to spite anyone. I just --

SAL: No? What do you call it when you crush your parents' dreams?

RON: I call it the truth.

SAL: Truth?

RON: Because it's what I want to do. It's my life.

INTRODUCTION

Almost every parent has a master plan for their offspring – they call it the American Dream: Go to college. Find a career you can commit to – doctor, lawyer, businessman. Get married, have kids, buy a house, retire, then watch your kids perform the same feats, in the same order. But what you belong to a family with a different master plan?

Get ready to turn parental guidance on its head. Ron's parents want him to succeed...at underachieving. They do everything in their power to keep him away from libraries, books and intelligent, motivated young women like his girlfriend Ashley. Instead they encourage him to spend his time at monster truck rallies, playing pool, and applying to technical college. Born to Be Blue by Mark Bellusci

SAL: So you're going to [throw] it away--

RON: [Throw] it away? You call going to (hesitates to say the word) . . . . I know what I'm doing.

SAL: You can't know. Don't you understand? You're too young to see-

RON: Look, this isn't permanent or anything. It's a four-year stint

SAL: Take it, and you're stuck for life.

RON: But I can do anything I want--

SAL: Anything you want. That's a laugh.

ASHLEY: Excuse me, I'm sorry for jumping in, but ... what are we talking about here?

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RON: It's okay--

ASHLEY: No, it's not okay. I mean, Ronnie has done something you should be proud of, and you're treating him like he killed someone.

SAL: **Himself**, if he takes this stint.

ASHLEY: "Stint?" It's four years at--

RON: Shhhh. They don't like to use its name in the house.

ASHLEY: They don't want to hear the word, "Harvard?"

GLORIA: Ohhhh! *(Sal makes a disgusted face.)*

ASHLEY: What could you possibly have against Harvard?

RON: Harvard, Yale, Princeton, they hate them all.

ASHLEY: Is ... is this one of those undercover video shows? Sure, you're a couple of out-of-work actors, right? *(Looking around.)* Come on, where's the camera? Where's the hack comedian host? I mean, Harvard! The best college in the world!

GLORIA: That's what they ***want*** you to believe.

ASHLEY: Do you know how many people would die for that scholarship?

GLORIA: How could a kid with a D-plus average get into Harvard on a full scholarship?

RON: I, uh, I doctored my report cards to make A's look like D's.

ASHLEY: *(Proudly.)* Ronnie scored the highest on the state aptitude test.

SAL: Did you at least cheat?

RON: I tried, but everyone else was putting in wrong answers.

GLORIA: That's because everyone else was listening to their parents, not sneaking around libraries.

ASHLEY: This is crazy. Absolutely--

GLORIA: What do you think happens when you go to Harvard?

ASHLEY: *(Sarcastic and rhetorical.)* You get a ... great education? Then, youuuu ... start your career.

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SAL: Ugggh. *(Gloria winces.)*

ASHLEY: *(To Ron)* That's another word I can't say? (Ron shakes his head no.) Okay, like, so what are you supposed to do after college?

GLORIA: Get a job.

ASHLEY: Job, career. What's the difference?

SAL: The difference is, a job, you do your eight hours and go home.

GLORIA: A career, you sacrifice your family, your leisure, your life, to "achieve" something.

SAL: A job you [complain] about, a career you see a therapist about.

ASHLEY: All right, so Ronnie will choose a job instead of a career. Fine. It's still--

GLORIA: This job he'll choose--you think it'll be high paying?

ASHLEY: It will if he comes out of Harvard.

GLORIA: And what color you think his collar will be?

ASHLEY: I don't know, shirts come in a lot of colors--

SAL: You think he's going to push paper or a broom?

ASHLEY: Paper!

SAL: Ah ha!

ASHLEY: Ah ha?

SAL: A white collar waste.

GLORIA: Headaches, ulcers, and a down-size away from a pink slip.

RON: Yeah, but the pay--

GLORIA: Less than minimum wage when you consider unpaid overtime.

SAL: Never mind the costs for a therapist . . . stress management sessions--

ASHLEY: Soooooo .... you want Ronnie toooooo .... not work?

GLORIA: Of course he'll work.

SAL: This country was built on work. Blue collar work.

ASHLEY: O ... kay. *(Sarcastically.)* So Ronnie should just forget about college.

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GLORIA: Absolutely not.

SAL: We've got a good school picked out for him. *(Clearing his throat, then intimidating a bad TV actor.)* "How did I get this wonderful job?" *(Continuing the TV actor imitation.)* "It all started the day I enrolled at Technical Career Institute."

GLORIA: Where Ronnie can learn to drive a dump truck.

SAL: Walk on to any construction site, and you'll be driving a dump truck in minutes.

GLORIA: Now that's a skill nobody can take away from you.

ASHLEY: What kind of life is that?

SAL: Are you kidding me? Best life there is.

GLORIA: Start at nine, home by five.

SAL: Talking sports with the guys.

GLORIA: Plenty of coffee breaks.

ASHLEY: But where's the challenge?

SAL: "Challenge?"

GLORIA: *(To Sal)* It's the high school counselors. They brainwash them.

ASHLEY: So instead of having a comfortable career in a nice office, you want him struggling to make money--

SAL: Struggling? You know what a good dump truck driver gets?

RON: Peanuts. I looked up their salary range.

GLORIA: You look at their overtime? Doubles the salary,

SAL: Now when was the last time some Harvard guy got overtime?

RON: Hey, with their salaries, they don't need it.

SAL: Oh yeah? And you think that Harvard guy gets to see any of that money?

GLORIA: *(Delivered fast and in monotone.)* Harvard guy pays for Harvard cars, parked in four-car Harvard garages, attached to thirty-two-room Harvard mansions, housing Harvard-to-be kids and a Harvard-kept wife.

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SAL: So at the end of the week, this rich Harvard guy's got just enough money left to buy a hot dog for lunch, and save the bun for dinner.

RON: And what, the blue collar guy doesn't have money problems?

GLORIA: Absolutely not.

SAL: He goes home, has dinner, goes to the kid's ball game, goes to Dairy Queen, goes to bed.

GLORIA: Clean, simple, affordable.

SAL: It's not too late, son. Classes that start Thursday could have you driving by Friday.

RON: What about the boredom? The same old thing, day in and day out?

SAL: No no no. See, you only get bored if you overdevelop your brain and start expecting more.

GLORIA: So many lost. What does it say for our country? *(Pause.)*

ASHLEY: Tell them. You tell them, or I will

RON: *(Sighing.)* This summer-- I'm going to-- I took a job.

SAL: You took a job. *(He takes out his pocket knife and holds it out to Ron)* Here. Just insert it between the third and fourth vertebrae.

GLORIA: I don't understand. We had your summer all planned. Get up at noon, hang on a street corner, go to the video arcade, see cheap horror movies, then shoot pool all night.

RON: I know, ma, but-- It's just that, I want to ***do*** something with my life.

SAL: You want to "do" something? Breathe in, breathe out, eat, sleep, [have] babies. Just let it happen.

ASHLEY: But you can't just let a career "happen." You've got to prepare for it, go to school for it.

GLORIA: *(To Sal)* Told you we should've done home education.

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SAL: All right, all right. *(Beat. He sighs.)* So what's this wonder job you got? Bartending, cutting lawns, what?

ASHLEY: *(Proud and defiant.)* Ron has been awarded one of only two internships at the city's largest law firm, Huff, Puff and Blowdon.

SAL: It's all over.

GLORIA: Don't you understand? They get their claws into you, they'll never let go.

RON: It's a great paying job, and I get credits towards college.

SAL: *(Offering his head to Ron)* Here, hit me in the temple. Make it fast and hard, and I'll be out of my misery in seconds.

RON: Pop, try to understand--

ASHLEY: *(Angry.)* How could two parents hold their son back from a chance of a lifetime? Aren't you supposed to want more for your son? Why should he settle for a blue collar job like yours?

RON: See, that's the thing. They're not blue collar people. My father's a college professor, and my mom's a senior vice president at IBM. *(Beat.)*

ASHLEY: What--? I don't-- Then why won't you let Ronnie have what you had?

SAL: Have what we?-- you know what we had?

GLORIA: Anxiety. Between his trying to get tenure.

SAL: And her never-ending trip up the corporate ladder. Barely saw each other the first ten years of marriage--and when we did, we didn't know what to do with ourselves.

GLORIA: Probably would've gotten divorced.

SAL: If we had the time.

GLORIA: Driven by our "careers"

SAL: Wanted to "do something" with our lives.

GLORIA: By the time we looked up, we weren't kids anymore. Then, out of the blue, the baby clock kicked in.

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SAL: We figured, have a few, hire a nanny, see the kids on weekends.

GLORIA: Be a good career move -- kids make a great impression at corporate outings. We scheduled a procreation appointment once a month.

SAL: That's when we learned, some things you can't plan for.

GLORIA: Like trying to create a kid on a deadline.

SAL: Our estimate for [a] baby was off.

GLORIA: Eight years off.

SAL: Well, eight years of trying does things to a couple. Because it-- it made us stop. And look at the way we were living. Constantly maneuvering to see what the next career move would be. And constantly looking over our shoulders to see who was gaining on us. *(Pause.)* So, we decided. [Forget] the career crap.

GLORIA: And [forget] the baby crap.

SAL: We were going to start living. Quit the jobs, sell the condo -- See the country.

GLORIA: We had enough saved. At least for a while. Then, after a few years, if the money got tight--

SAL: We'd take jobs. Job jobs.

GLORIA: Pay-the-bills jobs. Secretary.

SAL: *(Dreamily.)* Night watchman. Look at a few closed circuit cameras, sip some coffee, read my books -- and get paid for it? Man.

GLORIA: So that was our plan. And suddenly, everything was fun. We figured, if we wanted kids, we'd adopt. We were finally in control.

SAL: *(Chuckling.)* Yeah, for about a month. See, acting like teenagers did for us what eight years of planning couldn't do. *(ruffles Ron's hair – Ron was the product of less stress and more time)*

GLORIA: *(shrugs her shoulders)* And all those fun, new plans, out the door. So, I stayed at IBM.

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SAL: And I kept on at the college.

GLORIA: I was going to quit my job [but] your father got [caught up] in a politics game and wasn't granted tenure. *(To Ron)* Then you came along. And that sealed it, we were playing house for keeps.

SAL: So we put up with the long hours, the political backstabbing, the mind-numbing nonsense of white collardom-- But our children don't [have to].

GLORIA: Because a simpler life starts with a simpler job.

RON: It's -- It's too late, mom. I've already accepted the scholarship.

SAL: You raise them, you try to teach them--

RON: Pop, I -- I have to try this. But if it doesn't work – If it doesn't work . . . I'm – I'm still wearing . . . the belt. *(Ron lifts his shirt to reveal a carpenter belt filled with tools –)*

SAL: *(Sal and Gloria burst into smiles)* [His carpenter's belt!] He's till our boy, Gloria. *(Pause while Sal thinks, then he walks to the door and ushers Ron and Ashley out with these words)* Go ahead, see what the "career life" is all about. And when you're sick of it, we'll be here for you. *(Closes door, leans against it and sighs)*

GLORIA: It's just a phase, dear. He'll be back. And when he does, he'll be that much farther up the union apprentice list.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mark Bellusci
Book: Off-Off Broadway Festival Plays – Series No. 27
ISBN: 978-0573629075
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 2003

AWARD HISTORY

Ohio State Qualifier

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